

UX for Product Managers — Part II

Understanding design to be better PMs



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Photo by Kaboompics.com

Today we had a second session of our “UX for Product

Managers” workshop, that our own Laura Andina has prepared so well for our team of PMs, concluding this short but extremely illustrative course. To read about the first one, check this story we posted last week.

Today we’re going to tell you what we’ve focused on and why, and it will surely be useful to other Product Managers out there.

What we wanted to achieve

Beyond our main goal of becoming better Product Managers, with this second session we were looking to manage the following:

- Understand design and Designers
- Know what to look for
- Give better feedback
- Improve our UX skills

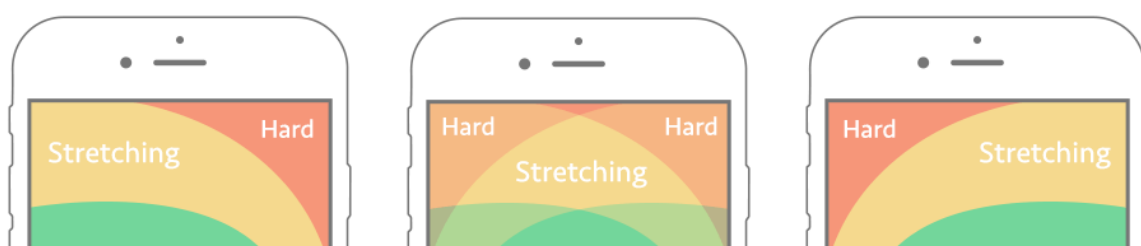
Understand design and Designers

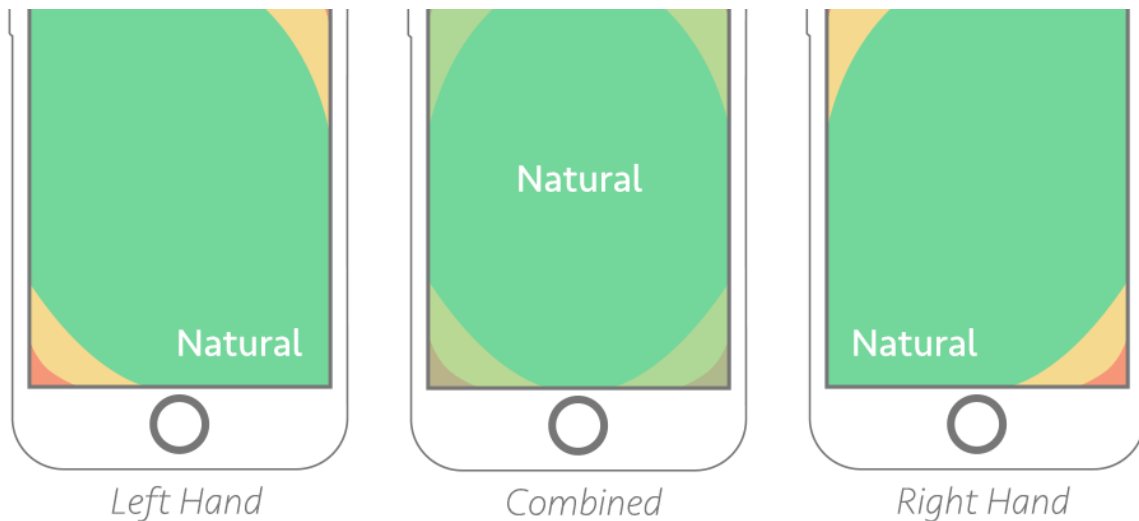
It’s very important for us not just to optimize ways of working with our designers, we also want to improve our relationships and the environment within our company. Understanding how they think, what’s their chain of thought to reach a solution for a problem is basic for us to be able to empathize better with our

teammates.

In the first part of today's session, Laura gave us a talk focusing on design theory. She went through various concepts to help us understand UX (our focus). Bare these two things in mind: we didn't have the time to dive deeper in a lot of the theory, and Laura talked about a lot of different things. A lot. So I'll just highlight the key learnings:

- **Follow the leader.** We build apps and websites. This is a pretty simple premise, but it's also highly effective: do as Apple does for iOS and Google does for Android. Laura encourages us to go through Apple's Human Interface Guidelines and Google's Material Design. It helps us understand patterns and know what to name things, but most importantly, if we follow these when building products, we can help our users because they'll already know how to use our app.
- **Understand your users.** Understand how they read a website ("F pattern of reading"), or how they interact with their smartphone (check image below). Skimming (users looking for the main idea) and scanning (users looking for a keyword).

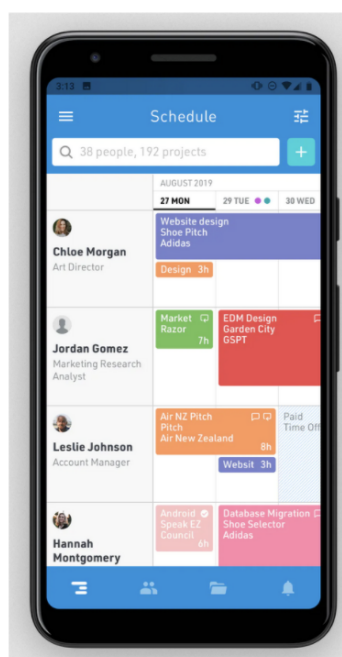




"The Thumb Zone" — check the full article here

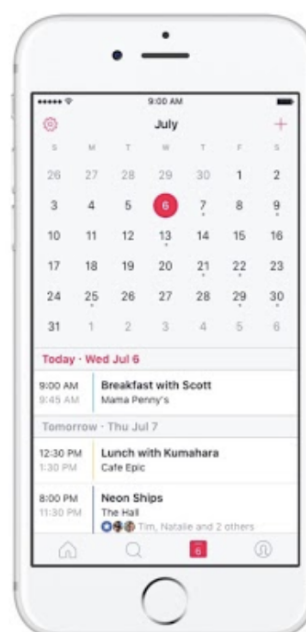
Book recommendation: "Don't Make Me Think", by Steve Krug.

- **Learn the name of things.** When everyone speaks the same language, it's easier to communicate. Knowing the "technical names" helps you bring closer designers and engineers, get understood, and be at the same level in the discussion.



Top app bar

Bottom nav bar



Nav bar

Tab bar

An example of the difference between Android and iOS and their names for some components

- Some **other design principles** of things that have widely been tested and validated. For example, the difference between adaptive and responsive design for a website. Or a little tip on icons: text alone is self-explanatory, and an icon is more helpful for a users to scan and quickly identify what they need to do. However, if you combine both, they work better.

Know what to look for

This was probably the most illuminating part of the session. Laura taught us who Jakob Nielsen is and presented him as the inventor of UX, which makes sense considering what we learnt today.

Not knowing what to look for is like looking with your eyes closed. With Nielsen's 10 usability heuristics, we improve our critical skills because we understand design and what it should accomplish much better.

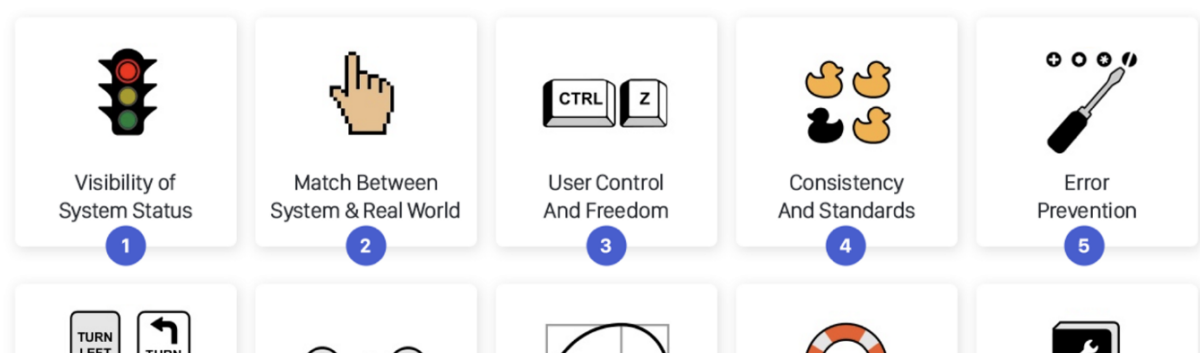




Image borrowed from 10 Usability Heuristics Every Designer Should Know, in UX Collective

Give better feedback

Now that we know what to look for (the 10 usability heuristics can serve as a template) and we can talk to designers “speaking in the same language”, we can provide more effective feedback.

We understand better which questions design has to answer, and it helps us give feedback to our designers in a more practical way and better oriented than ever.

Improve our UX skills

Of course, we also want to learn by doing. So once we’ve gone through the theory, the best way to learn is to apply what you know and practice with a real case.

Laura got all of us to work following the format of the first session. Three teams with the same assignment: perform a heuristic evaluation of Facebook, Twitter and Amazon (one per team). Quite a fun exercise to start practicing!

And now what?

Now we keep practicing, work better with our designers, and

prepare for our next course with the Analytics team. Care to guess what it will be about? :)

Thanks to Isabel Alonso Salcedo.

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